Early-Career Researchers

*Meet **Brendah Nyaguthii**, an early-career researcher at Mpala who will go on to complete her PhD at Australian National University. Brendah serves as project manager for the Vulturine Guineafowl project, run by the Max Planck Institute of Animal Behaviour.*

Tell us about your background.

I am an MSc graduate from the University of Eldoret in Kenya, where I studied Wildlife Management. I come from Kirinyaga county, which is approximately 400km away from the University. During my years at the university, I was an active member of the wildlife club that had several initiatives including museums, nature, environment and birdwatching. I was chosen to lead the club members in bird walks, which is how my passion for ornithology arose.

What brought you to Mpala?

I did research on the great white pelican at Lake Elementatita for my undergraduate project, and for my MSc I carried out research on the vuturine guinea fowl at Mpala Research Centre, where I currently work. I have also conducted research on birds in the Maasai Mara and Amboseli ecosystems.

What impact has your time at Mpala had on your professional career?

My goal is to see myself in the next five years as an independent researcher supporting my fellow young Kenyan scientists who want to follow the same career path as me. I foresee myself conducting my own research at Mpala in the near future and the time spent here will have shaped and molded me into the person I want to become. I will have gained a lot of experience to tackle anything related to research.

What is your favorite thing about working at Mpala?

One positive thing about working at Mpala is you get to meet different researchers who are willing to help and share their experiences. Mpala has given me a space where I have perfected my art of public speaking as I have given talks and presentations to different groups of people who have visited Mpala. I also appreciated the fact that Mpala is able to recognize and award people who have done well in their various jobs.

Interview by Daniel Persia (December 2022)